

Perfectionism: A Multidimensional Construct and Its Psychological Implications

Introduction

Perfectionism is a multidimensional personality construct described as possessing high performance standards accompanied by tendencies for self-critical evaluation while pursuing flawlessness.⁽¹⁾ From a psychoanalytic perspective, Freud believed perfectionism originates from the superego's demands for superior achievement.⁽⁴⁾ It is broadly divided into two dimensions: adaptive perfectionism, driven by a desire for success and satisfaction from effort, and maladaptive perfectionism, driven by fear of failure and a need to conceal imperfections.⁽⁴⁾ These are further operationalized as perfectionistic strivings (high personal standards and self-oriented pursuit of excellence) and perfectionistic concerns (feelings of discrepancy between expectations and results, concern over mistakes, and doubts about actions).⁽¹⁾

Perfectionism and Mental Health

A 2024 systematic review and meta-analysis by Callaghan et al. examined perfectionism's relationship with depression, anxiety, and OCD in adults aged 17–90 years.⁽²⁾ Findings revealed a significant small positive relationship between perfectionistic strivings and depressive symptoms, while perfectionistic concerns showed medium positive correlations with depression.⁽²⁾ No significant relationship was observed between perfectionistic strivings and social anxiety symptoms in either clinical or non-clinical samples.⁽²⁾ Importantly, the assumption that perfectionistic strivings are inherently "healthy" was challenged, as both dimensions were found to contribute to psychopathology, and strivings were associated with personal costs such as exhaustion and burnout.⁽²⁾ Clinical implications suggest that treatment should prioritize reducing perfectionistic concerns, as these demonstrated the strongest and most consistent associations with psychological disturbance.⁽²⁾

Perfectionism and Self-Esteem

A 2024 meta-analysis including 83 articles and 32,304 participants found that perfectionistic concerns were associated with a medium negative correlation with self-esteem, particularly pronounced in female-only samples ($r = -.55$) compared to mixed-gender samples ($r = -.40$).⁽⁵⁾ Perfectionistic strivings, by contrast, showed only a negligible positive association with self-esteem.⁽⁵⁾ Maladaptive perfectionism frequently engages cognitive patterns such as negative self-talk, overthinking mistakes, fear of criticism, and unrealistic expectations, all of which reduce self-worth and emotional wellbeing.⁽³⁾ The results support the cognitive-behavioral model of clinical perfectionism, wherein self-esteem becomes overly contingent on meeting demanding personal standards despite negative emotional consequences.⁽⁵⁾ Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT) targeting perfectionism has demonstrated efficacy in reducing symptoms of anxiety,

depression, and eating disorders, with a core aim of broadening individuals' bases of self-esteem.⁽⁵⁾

Perfectionism, Anxiety, and Academic Procrastination

A 2024 cross-sectional study among 255 Iranian medical and dental students investigated perfectionism and anxiety as predictors of academic procrastination—defined as the voluntary, irrational postponement of intended actions despite negative personal consequences.⁽¹⁾ Contrary to prior literature, none of the perfectionism dimensions significantly predicted procrastination; instead, anxiety emerged as the strongest predictor across the total sample ($\beta = 0.404$, $p < 0.001$), medical students ($\beta = 0.356$), and dental students ($\beta = 0.478$).⁽¹⁾ The authors suggested that students admitted to medicine and dentistry may develop more adaptive perfectionistic tendencies given the competitive nature of these programs.⁽¹⁾ Both anxiety and procrastination were negatively correlated with GPA, while perfectionism showed no significant correlation with academic performance.⁽¹⁾ A reciprocal relationship was also proposed: anxiety may prompt task avoidance, and procrastination may in turn amplify anxiety as deadlines approach.⁽¹⁾

Perfectionism and the Imposter Phenomenon in Medical Contexts

The imposter phenomenon (IP), first described by Dr. Pauline Clance, refers to an experience in which individuals feel they do not deserve their successes despite objective evidence to the contrary, fearing eventual exposure as frauds.⁽⁴⁾ A 2020 narrative review in the *International Journal of Medical Education* found IP prevalence ranging from 22.5% to 46.6% in medical trainees, with higher rates in females, and significant associations with anxiety and depression.⁽⁴⁾ The "Concern over Mistakes" dimension of perfectionism showed a significant positive association with IP scores, confirming a strong link between maladaptive perfectionism and impostor feelings in medical populations.⁽⁴⁾ Medical culture further reinforces these traits; surgical residents were found to construct perfectionism-valuing identities after socialization into surgical culture, while stigma surrounding mental health help-seeking impedes effective coping.⁽⁴⁾

Perfectionism in Youth Athletes

A 2026 study in *Psychology of Sport & Exercise* examined how a perfectionistic climate—an environment with unrelenting expectations of flawless performance and harsh criticism when standards are unmet—relates to trait perfectionism, resilience, fear of failure, and wellbeing in youth athletes.⁽⁶⁾ Socially prescribed perfectionism (SPP) was more strongly associated with fear of failure than self-oriented perfectionism (SOP).⁽⁶⁾ Positive, autonomy-supportive environments were linked to greater resilience, whereas controlling climates were associated with lower resilience and reduced wellbeing.⁽⁶⁾ Practical recommendations include framing success around

personal mastery rather than normative comparisons, normalizing mistakes as part of skill development, and providing process-focused feedback to foster long-term engagement.⁽⁶⁾

Conclusion

Across diverse populations and contexts, perfectionism consistently emerges as a psychologically significant construct. Perfectionistic concerns are more robustly linked to depression, low self-esteem, anxiety, and imposter phenomenon, while perfectionistic strivings show more variable associations.⁽²⁾⁽⁵⁾ In academic and medical settings, anxiety exerts a stronger influence on procrastination than perfectionism itself, and environmental and cultural factors—in both medical training and youth sport—meaningfully shape how perfectionistic traits are expressed and experienced.⁽¹⁾⁽⁴⁾⁽⁶⁾ Future research should prioritize longitudinal and experimental designs to determine causality, while clinical interventions should target perfectionistic concerns to reduce associated psychological burden.⁽²⁾⁽⁵⁾

References

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